

Class Malacostraca

Superfamily Majoidae

Spider crabs and relatives

Occurrence c.1,000 spp. in all but polar oceans and seas; from the intertidal zone to waters 6,500 ft (2,000 m) deep



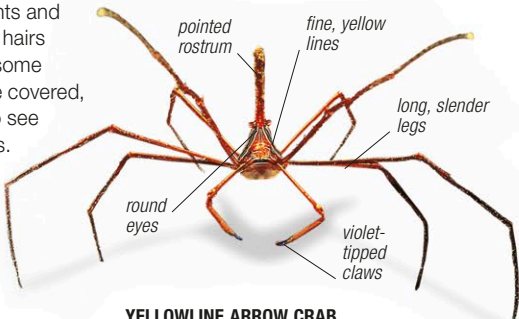
Spider crabs are recognized by their triangular carapace, a shape formed by a narrowing of the front edge, which is often extended as an elongated rostrum. As the common name implies, many species have long, slender legs. In most cases, the pincer-bearing legs (chelipeds) are not much longer than the other legs. Spider crabs use their chelipeds to attach sponges, seaweed, hydroids, and even detritus, such as wood fragments and broken worm tubes, to hooked hairs on their carapace and legs. In some species, the entire body can be covered, making the crab very difficult to see and protecting it from predators. If forced to move to a different location, some will change their camouflage to match their new surroundings. This behavior has given these

species the alternative names of decorating or masking crabs. Spider crabs range from small species with a carapace length of around $\frac{3}{16}$ in (8 mm) to the massive Japanese spider crab—also known as the giant spider crab—which has a carapace up to 20 in (50 cm) long (see below).



GIANT AMONG ARTHROPODS

The Japanese spider crab, *Macrocheira kaempferi*, is the world's biggest living arthropod. Its legs may be up to 5 ft (1.5 m) long.



YELLOWLINE ARROW CRAB

Yellow lines on the carapace, running backward from the eyes, and the arrow-shaped rostrum give this species, *Stenorhynchus seticornis*, its common name.

DIMINUTIVE FORM

The dainty yellowline arrow crab—at most, $2\frac{1}{2}$ in (6.5 cm) long—is found in the Atlantic Ocean from the Caribbean to as far south as Brazil. Males can tell how close a female is to laying eggs and, after they have mated, will guard the female from the attentions of other males.